

NUTRITION FOR CHILDREN WHO ARE SICK

A child's immune system is not fully developed until age three; toddlers average about seven colds a year. Around age three to five, children are exposed to many diseases after the antibodies from a mother's breast milk are excluded from their diet. Good nutrition is important in nursing children back to health. The belief that food should be discontinued during the illness is false. Common infectious diseases such as diarrhea or respiratory infections – can cause nutritional deficiencies in children.

Prepare foods that the child likes to stimulate his/her appetite.

- When a baby has diarrhea, loss of body fluids can be dangerous. For toddlers, breastfeeding should be maintained, if possible with higher frequency. Make sure older children drink plenty of fluids to prevent dehydration. Offer cereal or rice porridge, diluted with milk and water OR both. One should be careful giving cow's milk to children with diarrhea. Oral rehydration or rehydration salts can be given. Oral rehydration salts (ORS) mixes are a combination of dry salts mixed which need to be added to safe water. The mix can help replace the fluids lost due to diarrhea. ORS can be bought in pharmacies or prepared at home.
- If the child vomits, it is advisable to serve him/her food in small quantities until s/he can eat bigger portions. Easily digestible foods like puree and soups without fatty substances are preferred.
- Once the child recovers, the caregiver should add one meal a day during the first two weeks following his/her recovery. Add desserts between meals. For example:
 - ✓ Milk-based desserts
 - ✓ Yogurt with fruit or cereal flakes
 - ✓ Sweet potato
 - ✓ Bread with butter and jam
 - ✓ Fruit smoothies with milk and sugar, with cream or ice cream
 - ✓ Chicken and a hard-boiled egg, cheese and other sandwiches
- Additional doses of oil and sugar are encouraged during this time to restore his/her energy. Other options include the following:

- ✓ Enrich all meals with two teaspoons of fortified powder milk.
- ✓ Prepare meals (e.g. polenta, purees, cereals) with milk instead of water.
- ✓ Bake or grill pancakes and eggs.
- ✓ Add slices of fresh cheese to vegetable preparations.
- ✓ Add honey (for children older than 1 year) to fruit desserts and cakes.
- ✓ Incorporate a hard-boiled egg (full or chopped) into fillings and salads.

IDENTIFYING AND DEALING WITH ALLERGIES

- Children could be allergic to any food, but more likely to milk, eggs, wheat, fish and nuts. In addition to food, latex, insect stings and medicines can cause a severe allergic reaction in children.
- When introducing a new food to the child in your care, caregivers should keep an eye for allergic reactions such as hives, skin rashes, swellings, vomiting, diarrhea, coughing, difficulty breathing and loss of consciousness.
- Symptoms usually start anywhere between a few minutes or two hours after eating a food. Symptoms of an allergic reaction can appear one to six hours after the first symptoms disappear. This is called a biphasic reaction or a two-phase reaction.

Caregivers must keep a list of food types to which children are allergic and avoid them at all cost Sometimes inhaling the powder of peanuts, for example, can cause allergic reactions in children with allergies to peanuts.

- Caregivers must discuss emergency instructions with employers and should have the following at hand:
 - ✓ The number of emergency and rescue services
 - ✓ Script for calling emergency and rescue services, for example:

THIS IS AN EMERGENCY

My name is...and our address is...

A (X)-year-old child in my care is having severe food allergies. [Describe the symptoms and any care you have given him/her already, like for example a shot of epinephrine...]

Please send help. My phone number is...this is the passcode to the building...